The Tests of Faith Across Covenant History

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1. The Thesis, and the Vocabulary That Carries It

The thesis: in every era of God's covenant dealings with mankind, faith is not merely professed; it is tested. Each covenant contains occasions, commanded or providential, where trust in God's word must become visible action, at cost, against the counter-pressure of sight, appetite, fear, or culture.

Scripture has a technical vocabulary for this, and it is worth learning, because the thesis largely rides on it.

Hebrew. *Nasah*: to test, prove, put to the proof. This is the word in Genesis 22:1 ("God **tested** Abraham") and Deuteronomy 8:2. *Bachan*: to examine, assay, refine, used of God testing hearts as a metallurgist tests ore (Proverbs 17:3; Psalm 66:10; Zechariah 13:9).

Greek. *Peirazō / peirasmos*: test or trial, and in bad hands, temptation. *Dokimazō / dokimion / dokimos*: to test in order to approve; the assayer's word. James 1:12 uses it for the man who "has proven to be genuine." The two can describe the same event from two directions: God tests to prove and refine; Satan tempts to destroy (compare Job 1–2; Luke 22:31–32, where Satan demands to sift Peter like wheat and Jesus prays that his faith fail not).

James guards the doctrine at its most dangerous point: God tests, but God tempts no one toward evil (James 1:13). The test's purpose is never to make a man fall. It is to make his faith visible: to him, to the watching world, and, in covenant terms, on the record.

One connection to state up front, because it joins this study to the sacrifice framework: **a test is the scheduled occasion of sacrifice.** The test is the moment the invisible disposition is asked to pay something. Every test below has that shape.

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2. The Pattern, Era by Era

2.1 Eden: the command as test

Then the LORD God commanded the man, "You may freely eat fruit from every tree of the orchard, but you must not eat from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, for when you eat from it you will surely die." (Genesis 2:16–17)

An honest note first: Genesis never calls the tree a "test." The word *nasah* does not appear. But the structure is unmistakably a test's structure, and nearly every stream of Christian interpretation has read it so: one minimal command, surrounded by maximal permission ("from **every** tree… but"), with freedom to obey or refuse, and a stated consequence. The command was not burdensome; it was nearly costless to keep. Which is exactly what made it a pure test of trust: there was no reason to keep it *except* that God had spoken.

And notice what the serpent attacked: not Eve's morality but her confidence in the word by asking, "Is it really true that God said…?" (Genesis 3:1). The first test in Scripture, and the failure mode is the one that repeats through every era: the substitution of another standard of judgment ("the tree produced fruit… attractive… to make one wise," 3:6) for what God had said.

2.2 Noah: trust across a 120-year gap

By faith Noah, when he was warned about things not yet seen, with reverent regard constructed an ark for deliverance of his family. Through faith he condemned the world and became an heir of the righteousness that comes by faith. (Hebrews 11:7)

The Hebrews writer names the test's exact pressure point: "things **not yet seen**." Noah was asked to spend a lifetime of labor on the strength of a warning with no visible referent. Genesis marks the passing of the test with the obedience formula that becomes a refrain in Scripture: "And Noah did all that God commanded him; he did indeed" (Genesis 6:22; compare 7:5). The covenant that follows the flood (Genesis 9) is granted on the far side of the test.

2.3 Abraham: the explicit test

Here the vocabulary becomes explicit for the first time:

Some time after these things God **tested** Abraham. (Genesis 22:1)

The test is Moriah: "Take your son, your only son, whom you love, Isaac…" (22:2). Hebrews reads it as the definition of faith made visible: "By faith Abraham, when he was **tested**, offered up Isaac… he reasoned that God could even raise him from the dead" (Hebrews 11:17, 19). And James draws the conclusion that matters for this whole study: Abraham's faith "was working together with his works and his faith was perfected by works" (James 2:22); the test is where faith gets *completed*, not merely displayed.

Note also that Abraham's era had an entry-marker with the same structure: circumcision (Genesis 17), a commanded, costly, bodily act of covenant obedience, with exclusion attached to refusal (17:14). Keep that in view; Paul will connect it to the church's entry test in Colossians 2.

2.4 The Mosaic covenant: tests as covenant policy

Under Moses, testing stops being episodic and becomes stated divine policy. The texts are remarkably direct:

"I am going to rain down bread from heaven for you… so that I may **test** them. Will they walk in my law or not?" (Exodus 16:4)

The manna was a test: a daily one, with a weekly sabbath component built in (16:5, 19–30). Israel's forty years are then summarized, in Moses' retrospective, as one long examination:

Remember the whole way by which he has brought you these forty years through the desert so that he might, by humbling you, **test** you to see if you have it within you to keep his commandments or not. (Deuteronomy 8:2)

At Sinai: "God has come to **test** you, that the fear of him may be before you so that you do not sin" (Exodus 20:20). Even false prophets are folded into the policy: when a sign-worker arises urging other gods, "the LORD your God will be **testing** you to see if you love him with all your mind and being" (Deuteronomy 13:3). After the conquest generation, the nations left in Canaan are explicitly retained "to **test** Israel, whether or not they would obey the commandments of the LORD" (Judges 2:22; 3:4).

This is the era this thesis describes as "very specific covenantal acts of obedience," and the texts bear that out precisely: manna gathering, sabbath, dietary boundaries, festival attendance, tithes, the ban in holy war (Saul's failure, 1 Samuel 15). Each was a commanded act whose performance or refusal *revealed* the heart. Malachi even records God inviting a test in reverse on the tithe: "**Test** me in this matter, says the LORD who rules over all…" (Malachi 3:10).

2.5 Kings, prophets, and wisdom: the test internalized

The later Old Testament keeps the doctrine and drives it inward. "The crucible is for refining silver and the furnace is for gold, yet the LORD **tests** hearts" (Proverbs 17:3). "For you, O God, tested us; you refined us like silver" (Psalm 66:10). And the sobering case of Hezekiah, after a lifetime of faithfulness: when the Babylonian envoys came, "God left him alone to **test** him and to know his true motives" (2 Chronicles 32:31). The withdrawal of felt support was itself the test; Hezekiah, showing off his treasuries, failed it.

Job is the book-length treatment: a test the man never knows is a test, which is part of what makes it one.

2.6 Christ: the tested one

Everything converges here, and the thesis needs this section or it collapses into moralism.

Jesus is driven into the wilderness "to be tempted by the devil" (Matthew 4:1) (forty days answering to Israel's forty years), and he answers every test by quoting **Deuteronomy 6–8**, the very passages that interpret Israel's wilderness testing. He is deliberately retaking Israel's failed exam, and passing it. The manna test ("man does not live by bread alone": Deut 8:3) is his first answer.

Hebrews makes his testing the ground of ours: "he himself suffered when he was tempted, so he is able to help those who are being tempted" (2:18); he "has been tempted in every way just as we are, yet without sin" (4:15). And then the verse that fuses the whole study's vocabulary:

Although he was a son, he learned obedience through the things he suffered. And by being perfected in this way, he became the source of eternal salvation **to all who obey him**. (Hebrews 5:8–9)

The tested Son, having passed, becomes salvation's source, and the beneficiaries are described not as "all who feel," but "all who obey him." That verse is the bridge from covenant history into the church age.

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3. The Church-Age Tests: What the New Testament Specifies

Now the core question: does the New Covenant carry specific tests of the obedience of faith? The answer is yes, and they organize naturally into six categories. One precision before the list, because intellectual honesty here strengthens the case: the New Testament's explicit *test* vocabulary (peirasmos, dokimazō) attaches mostly to **trials, self-examination, and discernment**. The commanded covenant acts (confession, repentance, baptism, the Supper) are usually named as **obedience** rather than "tests." But two texts bridge the categories and license the thesis: Luke 7:29–30, where response to a commanded ordinance is treated as the revealer of a person's whole posture toward God's purpose, and 2 Corinthians 2:9, where an apostle says outright that he issues commands *in order to test obedience*. With that bridge in place, the catalog:

A. The entry test: obeying the gospel

The New Testament describes a person's initial response to Christ in obedience language, and treats it as the dividing test of the age:

- Paul: judgment falls on those who "do not obey the gospel of our Lord Jesus" (2 Thessalonians 1:8).
- Peter: "what will be the fate of those who **are disobedient to the gospel** of God?" (1 Peter 4:17).
- The gospel can be *obeyed* only because it contains commands. The apostolic preaching specifies them:

Faith confessed. "If you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved" (Romans 10:9). Confession before men is expressly a test with stakes (Matthew 10:32–33).

Repentance. God "now commands all people everywhere to repent" (Acts 17:30). A command universal in scope is a test universal in scope.

Baptism. "Repent, and each one of you be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins" (Acts 2:38). Here the thesis finds its sharpest single text, because Luke pauses his narrative to tell us what response to this ordinance *revealed*:

However, the Pharisees and the experts in religious law **rejected God's purpose for themselves, because they had not been baptized** by John. (Luke 7:29–30)

The commanded washing functioned exactly as the tree, the ark, and Moriah functioned: a concrete, seemingly modest act whose acceptance or refusal disclosed a person's entire posture toward God. The common people "acknowledged God's justice" by submitting to it (7:29); the religious experts refused, and the refusal was the verdict. Paul then supplies the covenant-continuity: baptism is the circumcision "performed without hands," the burial and resurrection with Christ "through your faith in the power of God" (Colossians 2:11–12): the New Covenant's entry-marker standing where the Abrahamic marker stood. And he describes conversion itself in test-passed language: "you **obeyed from the heart** that pattern of teaching you were entrusted to" (Romans 6:17).

B. The recurring covenantal test: the table

The Mosaic covenant scheduled its tests (weekly sabbath, annual feasts, daily manna). The New Covenant has a scheduled examination too, and the examination language is explicit:

A person should **examine himself** first, and in this way let him eat the bread and drink of the cup. (1 Corinthians 11:28)

The verb is *dokimazetō*: the assayer's word. The Lord's Supper is the only ordinance to which the New Testament attaches a standing, repeated, commanded self-test, with real consequences for taking it carelessly (11:27–30). Every week the covenant meal asks the covenant question. Alongside it stand the other recurring obediences whose neglect Scripture treats as revealing: the assembly itself (Hebrews 10:24–25: forsaking it is a symptom, not a scheduling problem), and forgiveness in prayer, which Jesus makes explicitly conditional and therefore diagnostic (Matthew 6:14–15).

C. The continuous tests: 1 John's "by this we know"

One New Testament book is structured entirely as a series of tests: 1 John, which older commentators called "the tests of life." Its refrain is *by this we know*:

- **The moral test.** "Now **by this we know** that we have come to know God: if we keep his commandments" (1 John 2:3). Claimed knowledge of God without obedience is called a lie outright (2:4).
- **The relational test.** "**By this we know** that we have crossed over from death to life: because we love our fellow Christians" (1 John 3:14; cf. 4:20–21: claimed love for the unseen God is falsified by hatred of the seen brother). Jesus had already made this the world-facing test: "Everyone will know by this that you are my disciples if you have love for one another" (John 13:35).

- **The doctrinal test.** "Do not believe every spirit, but **test** the spirits to determine if they are from God" (1 John 4:1), with confession of Christ come in the flesh as the assay (4:2–3). This is Deuteronomy 13 reissued for the church: false teachers are still, structurally, a test of whether the people love God more than signs.

Add John 8:31, "If you **continue** to follow my teaching, you are really my disciples," and the shape is clear: the continuous tests examine not single acts but persistence.

D. The providential tests: trials

Here the New Testament's explicit testing vocabulary is richest, and it deliberately echoes the wilderness:

My brothers and sisters, consider it nothing but joy when you fall into all sorts of trials, because you know that the **testing of your faith** produces endurance. (James 1:2–3)

Happy is the one who **endures testing**, because when he has **proven to be genuine**, he will receive the crown of life that God promised to those who love him. (James 1:12)

Peter supplies the metallurgy: trials come "so that the **genuineness of your faith** (infinitely more valuable than gold purified by fire) may bring praise and glory and honor when Jesus Christ is revealed" (1 Peter 1:6–7 paraphrased closely; cf. 4:12, where the "fiery ordeal… comes on you **to test you**"). Specific providential tests the New Testament names:

- **Persecution**: "Remain faithful even to the point of death, and I will give you the crown that is life itself" (Revelation 2:10; the suffering there is expressly "so that you may be **tested**").
- **Wealth and generosity**: Paul is startlingly plain: "I am not saying this as a command, but I am **testing the genuineness of your love**" (2 Corinthians 8:8), and the Jerusalem collection is called "the **evidence** of this service… your **obedience to your confession** in the gospel of Christ" (2 Corinthians 9:13). Money is the church age's manna: the daily proof of which master is actually served (Matthew 6:24).
- **The tongue**: James's first test of "religion" (James 1:26) and his measure of maturity (3:2).
- **Delay and ordinary time**: the parables of the absent master (Matthew 24:45–51; 25:14–30) frame the entire age as a stewardship examination whose defining pressure is that the master seems long in coming.

E. Apostolic-command tests

The most direct statement of the whole thesis in the New Testament is one Paul makes about his own letters:

For this reason also I wrote you: **to test you to see if you are obedient in everything.** (2 Corinthians 2:9)

Apostolic instruction is itself designed as a test of obedience, which is Romans 1:5 closing its own loop, since the apostleship existed "to bring about the obedience of faith among all the Gentiles." Compare Philippians 2:12 ("just as you have always **obeyed**… continue working out your salvation with awe and reverence") and 2 Thessalonians 3:14, where response to the letter sorts the congregation.

F. The self-test and the final test

The age ends in examination, and believers are told to pre-examine:

Put yourselves to the test to see if you are in the faith; **examine yourselves!** (2 Corinthians 13:5)

The Day itself is described as the final assay: "the fire will **test** what sort of work each has done" (1 Corinthians 3:13); Jesus stakes the last judgment scene of the Sermon on the Mount on the divide this whole study has traced: "Not everyone who says to me, 'Lord, Lord,' will enter into the kingdom of heaven, only the one who **does the will** of my Father in heaven" (Matthew 7:21), followed immediately by the two builders, where hearing-plus-doing versus hearing-alone is the difference the storm reveals (7:24–27). Revelation calls the eschatological crisis "the hour of **testing** that is about to come on the whole world" (3:10), and addresses every one of the seven letters "to the one who overcomes": conquest language presupposing a contest.

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4. The Pattern Across the Covenants

Era	Representative test	Text	What it asked
Eden	The tree	Gen 2:16–17	Trust God's word with no reason but the word
Noah	The ark	Gen 6:22; Heb 11:7	Costly obedience about "things not yet seen"
Abraham	Moriah; circumcision	Gen 22:1; Gen 17	Surrender the best; wear the covenant mark
Moses	Manna, sabbath, the ban, false prophets	Ex 16:4; Deut 8:2; 13:3	Daily, specific, commanded acts revealing the heart
Kings/Prophets	Withdrawal, refining, the tithe	2 Chr 32:31; Prov 17:3; Mal 3:10	The heart's true motives when unsupervised

Era	Representative test	Text	What it asked
Christ	The wilderness; Gethsemane	Matt 4; Heb 5:8	The Son retakes and passes every failed exam
Church	**Obey the gospel; the table; the "by this we know" life; trials; the Day**	**Acts 2:38; 1 Cor 11:28; 1 John; James 1; 2 Cor 13:5**	**The obedience of faith, entered, repeated, sustained, proven**

Four structural observations:

1. Every covenant pairs an entry test with continuing tests. Circumcision then the law; baptism then the table and the life. The entry test is decisive; the continuing tests are diagnostic. Confusing the two produces either one-time religion (entry without continuance) or anxious religion (continuance with no settled entry).

2. Every test targets the same seam. From the serpent's "Is it really true that God said?" to Malachi's blemished lambs to the scoffers of 2 Peter 3 ("Where is his promised return?"), the test is always whether God's word outweighs sight, appetite, fear, delay, and expert opinion. The eras change; the seam does not.

3. The test is where faith becomes visible: the test is the appointment for sacrifice. Genesis 22 is simultaneously the Bible's paradigm test and its paradigm sacrifice, and that is not a coincidence. A test with no cost tests nothing. This study and the sacrifice study are one study.

4. The church's tests sit on the far side of a passed exam. This is the difference grace makes, and the thesis must say it loudly: Christ has already taken Israel's test, Adam's test, and passed (Matthew 4; Hebrews 5:8–9). The believer's tests are therefore not probation to earn standing but the proving and refining of a faith already resting on a finished work: "the proven character of your faith" unto "praise and glory and honor when Jesus Christ is revealed" (1 Peter 1:7). Hebrews 12 accordingly reframes all of it as a father's *discipline* of sons, not an examiner's gatekeeping of applicants. We are tested as family, not as candidates.

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5. Honest Calibrations

Eden is a structural test, not a labeled one. Expressively, "the command functioned as a test" rather than "Scripture calls the tree a test" (which Scripture does not do explicity).

Distinguish the two kinds of church-age tests. Commanded covenant acts (confession, repentance, baptism, the Supper) are *obediences that function as tests*: Luke 7:29–30 and 2 Corinthians 2:9 (warrant for the functional claim). Providential trials (James 1; 1 Peter 1, 4) carry the

explicit *test* vocabulary (categorically distinct - "obey" versus "test" language that should not be blurred.).

Guard against a works-righteousness reading. The tests do not generate standing; they prove and complete faith (James 2:22) within a covenant entered "by the mercies of God" (Romans 12:1). The order every time is: mercy first, then the tests, exactly as Israel was redeemed from Egypt *before* the wilderness examination, not by it. Deuteronomy 8:2 comes after the exodus, never before it.

The Hezekiah case does quiet work. 2 Chronicles 32:31 establishes that mature believers are still tested, that felt divine absence can *be* the test, and that a lifetime of passed tests guarantees nothing about the next one. It is this text that keeps this doctrine humble.